Assignment Report
Assignment 2: Personas
Leander Earnesteen

1. System Description

The intent is to build a system that helps visiting and exchange students at USI integrate into the student community and also with other visiting students during their stay in Lugano.

The proposed system focuses on building a digital space for the exchange student community in Lugano. It aims to act as a space where students can access relevant activities, exchange information, ask questions, and connect with other members of the exchange student community.

2. User Characteristics

Based on the nine interviews conducted, several characteristics were identified that provided a perspective into how the visiting students engage with social events and the student community.

One important difference concerns social motivation and integration. Some students actively seek opportunities to meet new people, while others prefer participating in activities with familiar faces or an already established group of friends. There was also a difference in their preferences, with some preferring large organized events versus smaller, more personal gatherings.

Another relevant characteristic is event discovery and information-seeking behaviour. Exchange students have access to different channels, including WhatsApp groups, university communication, and word of mouth, to discover activities. While some find these convenient, others experience difficulties navigating large volumes of messages, discovering activities outside established networks and keeping track of the various events.

Finally, the stage of the exchange experience influences students' needs. Newly arrived students may rely more on organized activities to network, while students who have managed to develop a social circle may become more selective and prefer independently organized activities in the later stages of their exchange.

These differences suggest that visiting students should not be treated as a homogeneous group, even if they all deal with the same systems as exchange students.

3. Design Persona and Selection Process

Following the approach prescribed in the book, the interview findings were examined to identify recurring goals, behaviours, motivations, and frustrations relevant to our proposed system.

From these transcripts, the following persona of a Visiting Social Explorer was chosen as the primary design persona because their needs were supported by multiple interviews and closely aligned with the two central areas of our proposed system: event discovery and community interaction.

This persona is built through characteristics observed across several interviews rather than one specific participant.

3.1 Primary Persona: The Visiting Social Explorer

3.1.1 Background:

A visiting student who has recently arrived in Lugano for an exchange semester. They are excited about experiencing a new environment and meeting people but have not established a strong social network yet.

3.1.2 Goals

Build meaningful friendships, discover relevant exchange activities for an immersive experience, feel included in the student community, and make the most of their limited time abroad.

3.1.3 Behaviors

Uses existing student communication channels and recommendations from peers to discover events. Often considers whether acquaintances will attend before participating and prefers activities that encourage tighter social interaction.

3.1.4 Frustrations

Large events can feel impersonal, information about activities may be scattered across different channels, and participating without knowing others can feel uncomfortable. Also difficulties with keeping track of various events, oftentimes being unaware of particular events in case they aren't active in the social media channels.

3.1.5 Needs

Accessible event information, opportunities to connect with students who share similar interests, and approachable ways to participate in community activities.